

# Eastern Sparks

## Companion Workbook

---

Exercises, wine pairings, and service scenarios  
drawn from each of the twelve chapters.

Answers at the back.

## HOW TO USE THIS WORKBOOK

---

### SUPPLEMENTAL MATERIAL

Eastern Sparks and this workbook are supplemental to the ServeMaster Academy course and app. The novel brings the skills to life through story; the app is where you practise, certify, and track your progress. Use both together for the full experience.

**Each chapter has three parts:**

#### **Knowledge Check**

Four multiple-choice questions on wine, service technique, and the chapter setting. One best answer - the others represent common mistakes or partial truths.

#### **Service Scenario**

An open-ended situation drawn from the chapter's key service moment. Write freely, then review against your own experience.

#### **Skills Checklist**

Five statements about the chapter's core skills. Tick what you own, circle what you're working on. Return after your next shift.

---

Answers to the Knowledge Check are in the Answer Key at the back, with a brief explanation of why each answer is correct and what makes the wrong answers wrong.

## CHAPTER 1

# Tokyo / Separate Mastery

Tokyo, Japan - Ginza restaurant / Sezanne at Four Seasons Marunouchi

### CHAPTER SUMMARY

Sofia joins a precise Ginza room where Matsuda-san corrects her sake service with two words - "too many words" - and Keiko later gives her the concept of "ma," the interval or space that gives service its shape. Across the city Luca works the floor at Sezanne under Remy, learning that junmai daiginjo is not wine but its own logic of rice polishing and serving temperature, and that "defensible is the enemy of right." A returning guest, William Daniels, teaches Luca that systems are only the vessel - the people inside them are the point.

### KNOWLEDGE CHECK

**1. Matsuda-san corrects Sofia's sake presentation with the diagnosis:**

- A) "You moved too fast"
- B) "Too many words"
- C) "Stand closer to the guest"
- D) "Describe the rice first"

**2. The concept of "ma" that Keiko gives Sofia refers to:**

- A) A style of pouring sake from height
- B) The interval or space - the pause that gives service its shape
- C) A formal bow used to greet regulars
- D) The rice-polishing ratio of premium sake

**3. Remy explains that for junmai daiginjo, serving temperature is:**

- A) A guest preference with no effect on flavor
- B) Always cold to preserve aroma
- C) An instrument - cold narrows and sharpens, warm amplifies umami
- D) Irrelevant compared to the rice-polishing ratio

**4. When William Daniels asks Luca what he would drink, Luca recommends the Juyondai because:**

- A) It is the most expensive sake on the list
- B) The kitchen is working in restraint and the sake matches that quiet register
- C) It is what most guests order
- D) It pairs with every course equally

### SERVICE SCENARIO

A Japanese host has brought an American client to your counter and you are presenting the sake. You want to show your expertise, and the American leans in, interested, while the host stays impeccably polite.

Using Sofia's Tokyo lesson, walk through how you calibrate what you say and how much you say - and explain why removing words is not the same as removing warmth.

---

---

---

---

### SKILLS CHECKLIST

Tick what you own - Circle what you're working on - Leave blank what you haven't started

- ☐ I let silence do work instead of filling every pause with description
- ☐ I match the amount I say to what the guest actually needs, not to what I want to demonstrate
- ☐ I treat sake as its own logic - rice polishing and serving temperature - not as translated wine
- ☐ I choose the useful truth for this guest tonight rather than the defensible one
- ☐ I remember the system is the vessel and the person in front of me is the point

## CHAPTER 2

# Bangkok / Heat, Tempo, Orbit

Bangkok, Thailand - Nusara (Luca) / French room near Silom and Lumpini (Sofia)

---

### CHAPTER SUMMARY

Bangkok teaches tempo. At Nusara, Khun Nok tells Luca "faster for this table," and he learns that his careful Tokyo intervals were themselves the imprecision - the room had a temperature and he had been serving his own sense of order. At her French room near Lumpini, Sofia guides a nervous husband at a birthday table toward a dry rose from Pic Saint-Loup in the Languedoc, then reads a mixed-register table and brings four guests to the same warmth without pushing anyone there.

### KNOWLEDGE CHECK

1. **Khun Nok corrects Luca mid-service at the six-top with the instruction:**
  - A) "Slow down for this table"
  - B) "Faster for this table"
  - C) "Say less to this table"
  - D) "Give them the tasting menu"
2. **The rose Sofia recommends at the birthday table is a dry wine from:**
  - A) Provence
  - B) Pic Saint-Loup in the Languedoc
  - C) Bandol
  - D) Tavel in the Rhone
3. **Sofia's handling of the mixed-register table (warm local hosts, reserved London couple) shows that:**
  - A) You should match the warmest guests to set the tone
  - B) You should cool the whole table to the most reserved guest
  - C) The warmest move is bringing everyone to the same place without anyone feeling pushed
  - D) You should let the hosts manage their own guests
4. **When a family writes from Paris praising his recommendation, Luca learns from Khun Nok that:**
  - A) He should immediately promise to do better next time
  - B) He should allow true praise to land cleanly instead of converting it to future pressure
  - C) He should share the credit with the kitchen
  - D) He should thank the guest in writing

### SERVICE SCENARIO

**A six-top of celebrating guests arrives already loud, laughing, and full of momentum, and you have paced their first courses with careful, elegant intervals - but the host keeps glancing toward the kitchen.**

**Describe how you read the table's temperature, what you change, and why serving at the table's tempo is a form of precision rather than a loss of it.**

---

---

---

---

---

### SKILLS CHECKLIST

Tick what you own - Circle what you're working on - Leave blank what you haven't started

- ☐ I read the temperature of the table in front of me instead of repeating the last table's rhythm
- ☐ I adjust my pace to the guests rather than to my own sense of order
- ☐ I recommend wine that lifts the kitchen instead of competing with it
- ☐ I bring a mixed table to shared warmth through sequence, not by flattening anyone
- ☐ I let honest praise land cleanly instead of turning it into future pressure

## CHAPTER 3

# Yaowarat / Evidence

Bangkok, Thailand - Yaowarat (Chinatown) street food

### CHAPTER SUMMARY

Arno drags a group of floor and hotel people to Yaowarat after midnight and finally introduces Sofia and Luca, ending nearly two years of failing to meet. Over an oyster omelet counter, grilled squid, satay, and a stockpot of boat noodles, they discover they have been arriving at the same service instincts from opposite directions. Deep into the night they trade the shifts that changed them - Luca's widower in Paris, Sofia's woman moved to tears by an orange-blossom cake - and exchange numbers before parting.

### KNOWLEDGE CHECK

1. What first makes Luca recognize Sofia at Yaowarat before he sees her face?

- A) Her uniform
- B) Her laugh, carrying a soft Portuguese shape
- C) Arno calling her name
- D) The notebook in her vest

2. Sofia identifies that Luca carries a notebook by:

- A) Asking him directly
- B) Noticing his left pocket prints rectangular and he touched it twice before sitting
- C) Seeing him write in it
- D) Arno mentioning it

3. The dish they share at the last stall, from a long-simmered near-black stockpot, is:

- A) Pad thai
- B) Boat noodles
- C) Congee
- D) Tom yum

4. When Luca describes staying "one beat past the safe answer" with the Paris widower, Sofia says it is:

- A) Too risky for most guests
- B) The whole job
- C) Something only instinct can teach
- D) Better left to management

### SERVICE SCENARIO

A solo diner at a quiet table stops eating for about twenty seconds mid-course, spoon in hand, clearly somewhere else. You ask if everything is all right and he says yes - but his hand does not go back to the bowl.

Walk through what you do next, how long you stay, and how you decide whether to gently open a door or leave the guest their privacy.

---

---

---

---

---

### SKILLS CHECKLIST

Tick what you own - Circle what you're working on - Leave blank what you haven't started

- ☐ I read a guest's hands, posture, and pauses to sense what they have not said
- ☐ I am willing to stay one beat past the technically safe answer when a guest needs it
- ☐ I give a guest space to feel something without rushing to rescue them too fast
- ☐ I never make a moved guest apologize for their own feeling at my table
- ☐ I let the room slow around a guest without making them aware I have done it

## CHAPTER 4

# After Evidence / Daily Contact

Bangkok, Thailand - text thread, Chatuchak market, riverside shophouses

### CHAPTER SUMMARY

After Yaowarat, Luca sends a photo of the cleared stall - "Evidence we didn't dream it" - and a daily text thread grows in the gaps between services, built on useful things rather than flirtation. Sofia handles an anniversary four-top where a mistimed joke threatens the center of the evening, protecting the couple with a private, angled acknowledgment; Khun Fon praises her for correcting the temperature without touching the thermostat too hard. They spend a Saturday reading Chatuchak market like a dining room and begin discussing Singapore.

### KNOWLEDGE CHECK

**1. Khun Fon praises Sofia's anniversary-table save with the line:**

- A) "You read the room before it spoke"
- B) "You corrected the temperature without touching the thermostat too hard"
- C) "You gave them the evening they booked"
- D) "You protected the center of the table"

**2. How does Sofia physically create privacy for the anniversary couple?**

- A) She takes them to a different table
- B) She lowers the lights over their table
- C) She positions her body at an angle and pitches her voice down so only they hear
- D) She asks the other couple to step away

**3. When Sofia corrects a junior who called a Chenin Blanc "friendly," Luca advises:**

- A) Let the junior learn from the guest's reaction
- B) Tell him friendliness is not a tasting note unless the wine did him a personal favor
- C) Have the junior re-taste the wine
- D) Give the table a different bottle

**4. At Chatuchak, Sofia realizes Luca is "reading the room" because he:**

- A) Refuses to enter crowded lanes
- B) Maps traffic density, queue length, and which stalls locals trust - while thinking he is just shopping
- C) Asks vendors technical questions
- D) Buys only from the first stall he sees

### SERVICE SCENARIO

An anniversary four-top has drifted: a well-meaning joke from a visiting couple keeps landing for two guests and not the two whose night it actually is, and you see the host's wife's smile begin to close.

Explain how you re-center the evening on the couple who matter without embarrassing the other guests or turning the anniversary into a public announcement.

---

---

---

---

---

### SKILLS CHECKLIST

Tick what you own - Circle what you're working on - Leave blank what you haven't started

- ☐ I read a table's emotional center and protect it without announcing that I have
- ☐ I use my body position and voice level to create privacy inside a full room
- ☐ I correct a colleague's wine language without humiliating them in front of guests
- ☐ I build trust with a guest through repeated small, useful acts rather than performance
- ☐ I keep one table's weather from migrating into another's

## CHAPTER 5

# The Story Points to Her

Bangkok, Thailand - Nusara

### CHAPTER SUMMARY

William Daniels returns to Nusara with his supplier Chanin, and Luca recommends a Thai white - Monsoon Valley Colombard - to begin, then cold beer, describing Bangkok itself. When an American guest objects that her dish smells of fish sauce rather than the promised tamarind, Luca finds the real concern beneath the wrong noun and offers a spoon with broth beside it; Khun Nok praises him for correcting the note without embarrassing the note. Over a late beer, William's decades-old Paris story about a Brazilian server finally resolves in Luca's mind - it points to Sofia - just as his Singapore placement is confirmed.

### KNOWLEDGE CHECK

**1. To begin William and Chanin's meal, Luca recommends which Thai wine?**

- A) Monsoon Valley Colombard
- B) A Thai Chenin Blanc
- C) An off-dry Riesling
- D) Monsoon Valley Shiraz

**2. When the guest says her dish smells of fish sauce rather than tamarind, Luca understands that:**

- A) The kitchen made an error and the dish must be remade
- B) Guests often choose the wrong noun for the correct discomfort
- C) She is simply being difficult
- D) The reservationist over-promised the dish

**3. Khun Nok's praise for the recovery is:**

- A) "You saved the table"
- B) "You corrected the note without embarrassing the note"
- C) "You gave her a real choice"
- D) "You listened before you spoke"

**4. What clues in William's Paris story make Luca realize it points to Sofia?**

- A) The restaurant name and the year
- B) Brazilian Portuguese, a bright laugh, and describing a dish as if she had listened to the plate first
- C) A shared mutual friend
- D) The wine she recommended

### SERVICE SCENARIO

**A guest stops a runner and says, with a too-complete smile, that her dish smells of fish sauce when she was told on the phone it would taste of tamarind. Technically nothing is wrong with the plate.**

**Describe how you find the real concern beneath her wording and give her back a genuine decision - without apologizing for a dish that did not fail or blaming whoever described it to her.**

---

---

---

---

---

### SKILLS CHECKLIST

Tick what you own - Circle what you're working on - Leave blank what you haven't started

- ☐ I listen for the real discomfort even when a guest names the wrong cause
- ☐ I offer a guest a genuine choice instead of a diplomatic apology
- ☐ I recommend wine and drinks that describe the place and the menu honestly
- ☐ I correct information without embarrassing the person who carried it
- ☐ I let an honest recommendation invite the guest to become active in their own evening

## CHAPTER 6

# The Faster Rhythm

Singapore - Odette at the National Gallery

### CHAPTER SUMMARY

Sofia arrives in Singapore, where Luca has already mapped the city, and joins the floor at Odette inside the National Gallery - a room that teaches by subtraction and runs faster than Bangkok. Claire tells her to learn the sightlines first and not to charm when precision will do. Mei raises the question of the tip pool: she sold a 2012 Pauillac from the reserve list at two thousand and forty dollars yet took home nearly the same as a colleague who ran ninety-dollar Viogniers, because the pool is weighted by total covers and total sales to protect the whole floor.

### KNOWLEDGE CHECK

**1. Claire's early guidance to Sofia at Odette is:**

- A) Charm every table before you read it
- B) Learn the sightlines first, and do not charm when precision will do
- C) Always offer the longest tasting menu
- D) Never speak until spoken to

**2. The high-value bottle Mei sold from the reserve list was a:**

- A) 2012 Pauillac at \$2040
- B) 2015 Barolo at \$1800
- C) 2012 Meursault at \$900
- D) 2010 Chateauneuf-du-Pape at \$2040

**3. The Odette tip pool is weighted by:**

- A) Total sales only
- B) Total covers and total sales
- C) Seniority and hours worked
- D) Individual table assignments

**4. Claire's honest defense of the flattened pool is that:**

- A) It rewards the best individual sellers
- B) The system works for the house, though it does not always work for the person
- C) It is required by law
- D) It prevents servers from competing at all

### SERVICE SCENARIO

A talented junior server confides that she executed an exceptional sale on a high-value reserve bottle, gave the guests a flawless experience, and still took home roughly the same as a colleague who poured house wine all night, because the tip pool is weighted for the whole floor.

Walk through how you respond to her in the moment, and how you would think through the fairness and purpose of a shared pool.

---

---

---

---

---

### SKILLS CHECKLIST

Tick what you own - Circle what you're working on - Leave blank what you haven't started

- ☐ I learn a room's sightlines and grammar before I rely on charm
- ☐ I choose precision over performance when the room rewards precision
- ☐ I can explain how a weighted tip pool protects support staff and the whole floor
- ☐ I acknowledge a colleague's excellent work even when the system does not visibly reward it
- ☐ I hold open a fair question about how a system was designed without pretending I have the answer



## CHAPTER 7

# Pressure Becomes Real

Singapore - Odette at the National Gallery

### CHAPTER SUMMARY

Sydney asks Luca for a real conversation, and Claire warns him that distraction enters through half-seconds, not spectacle. He intercepts an unnecessary amuse the assistant manager wants to send to a VIP table, insisting they value privacy and pace over theater, and Sofia arrives with cover to back him. Taking more of the floor herself, Sofia handles a stalling hedge-fund four-top with the line "I can keep three excellent paths open for you for another minute - after that, one of them stops being real," and Claire notes she did not flatter delay by calling it sophistication.

### KNOWLEDGE CHECK

**1. Claire warns Luca that distraction on an elite floor shows up as:**

- A) Dropped plates and visible mistakes
- B) Half-seconds - a junior left waiting, a host read twice
- C) Slower walking speed
- D) Forgetting the menu

**2. Luca refuses to send the extra amuse to the VIP table because:**

- A) The kitchen is too busy
- B) The guests value privacy and pace, and it would read as theater
- C) Regional did not approve it
- D) It would slow the pacing for other tables

**3. Sofia moves the stalling hedge-fund four-top to a decision by saying:**

- A) "You need to order now, please"
- B) "I can keep three excellent paths open for you for another minute - after that, one of them stops being real"
- C) "The kitchen is closing that option soon"
- D) "Let me choose for you"

**4. Claire's praise for Sofia's handling of the four-top is that she:**

- A) Was faster than expected
- B) Did not flatter them by pretending delay was sophistication
- C) Sold them the most expensive menu
- D) Let them take their time

### SERVICE SCENARIO

A four-top keeps circling the same three menu questions, treating open options as a form of care while three genuinely good choices slowly downgrade to merely adequate ones. Management wants you to keep them comfortable.

Describe how you let them feel ownership of the decision, when you name a real cutoff, and how you say it so it reads as diagnosis rather than pressure.

---

---

---

---

---

### SKILLS CHECKLIST

Tick what you own - Circle what you're working on - Leave blank what you haven't started

- ☐ I keep future distractions out of the half-seconds of my service
- ☐ I refuse unnecessary touchpoints that read as theater to guests who want privacy and pace
- ☐ I give strong tables clarity instead of false optionality
- ☐ I name a real decision cutoff before indecision turns into decay
- ☐ I back a colleague by arriving with cover instead of adding to the problem

## CHAPTER 8

# Futures That May Split Them

Singapore - Odette / Empress Place riverside

### CHAPTER SUMMARY

Buenos Aires reaches Sofia through Camila Ortega, whose questions make it clear a serious room is asking for her specifically, with a possible January stage; Sydney firms up for Luca in the same week. The Koh anniversary four-top arrives with a structural problem - a daughter who must leave repeatedly for legal calls - and Sofia reframes it as a reentry architecture problem, managing returns rather than absences while Luca builds a clean landing for each reentry. Walking the river, they give each other the honest, unromanticized versions of their futures and agree not to ask each other to become smaller.

### KNOWLEDGE CHECK

**1. Sofia reframes the Koh table's challenge as:**

- A) A timing problem
- B) A reentry architecture problem - managing returns, not absences
- C) A seating problem
- D) A dietary problem

**2. How does Luca handle the daughter's reentry after her longest call?**

- A) He apologizes for the delay on the family's behalf
- B) He waits at the edge of the table, not in her path, and says she has missed nothing important
- C) He announces her return to the table
- D) He re-explains each course she missed

**3. What steadies Sofia most about Camila's Buenos Aires interview?**

- A) The salary offered
- B) That it sounded like a serious room asking for her specifically, not a competency screen
- C) That the city was glamorous
- D) That the start date was flexible

**4. On the river walk, the deepest form of care Sofia and Luca manage is:**

- A) Promising to stay in the same city
- B) Not wanting less for each other, but helping the other want honestly
- C) Avoiding the subject of leaving
- D) Making firm long-distance plans

### SERVICE SCENARIO

An anniversary four-top includes one guest who must step away repeatedly to take urgent, high-stakes calls, while another guest at the table pushes for momentum and the rest quietly absorb the disruption.

Explain how you plan for her returns rather than her absences, how you coordinate with the kitchen, and how you make each reentry feel effortless without turning her situation into a spectacle.

---

---

---

---

---

### SKILLS CHECKLIST

Tick what you own - Circle what you're working on - Leave blank what you haven't started

- ☐ I plan for a guest's returns, not just their absences, when a table's shape is unstable
- ☐ I build a clean reentry so a guest never has to catch up publicly
- ☐ I give gratitude nowhere to go so a guest can return it to the people who matter to them
- ☐ I coordinate two fire maps with the kitchen so a modification is never rediscovered mid-service
- ☐ I support a colleague and a guest without asking either to become smaller

## CHAPTER 9

# The Room Under Strain

Singapore - Odette at the National Gallery, holiday week

### CHAPTER SUMMARY

Holiday week fills the room with competing emotional temperatures, and Claire lays down the rule that guests should not have to explain something important twice because a handoff failed. Table nine - the Lee family, with a severe shellfish allergy - tests exactly that when a junior runner nearly asks aloud "who had the shellfish," and Luca intercepts, taking ownership so the daughter never has to identify herself in front of her family. Afterward, Luca names the principle he wants to carry into their own coming separation: guests should only explain once.

### KNOWLEDGE CHECK

**1. Claire's operational rule for holiday week is that:**

- A) Every table should get festive warmth
- B) If a guest tells us something important once, they should not have to explain it again
- C) Speed matters more than anything else
- D) Runners should double-check every allergy at the table

**2. When a junior runner starts to ask "who had the shellfish," Luca intercepts because:**

- A) The runner had the wrong tray
- B) It would force the daughter to publicly identify herself as the guest with the allergy in front of her family
- C) The kitchen had already handled it
- D) The allergy note was wrong

**3. The service architecture Luca and Sofia use for the allergy table is:**

- A) Multiple staff verifying with the guest each course
- B) One owner, one allergy path, one table memory
- C) Rotating handoffs to spread the workload
- D) Kitchen-led control with no floor verbal checks

**4. The principle Luca draws for himself and Sofia from the night is:**

- A) Always have a backup plan
- B) Guests should only explain once
- C) Speed protects dignity
- D) Never let a table see the save

### SERVICE SCENARIO

A returning family table includes a guest with a severe shellfish allergy noted once at booking, and during a busy holiday service a new runner is about to ask aloud at the table which guest has the allergy.

Walk through how you take ownership so the guest is protected both from harm and from having to publicly identify herself, and how you correct the runner without humiliation.

---

---

---

---

---

### SKILLS CHECKLIST

Tick what you own - Circle what you're working on - Leave blank what you haven't started

- ☐ I make sure a guest never has to explain an important thing twice
- ☐ I take single ownership of a high-risk table so nothing depends on a failed handoff
- ☐ I protect a guest's dignity, not just their safety, around a medical need
- ☐ I correct a junior in the moment without shaming them
- ☐ I keep an allergy modification invisible to the rest of the table throughout the meal

## CHAPTER 10

# Decision Cutoff / Final Singapore Evenings

Singapore - Odette / staff housing / Marina Bay

### CHAPTER SUMMARY

With Sydney and Buenos Aires now printed addresses, Luca and Sofia sort his guest-handoff notes into categories - sacred, useful, vanity, and escalate if - and he quietly recognizes it as a scoring rubric worth keeping. William Daniels warns that people claim to want strong systems then build them around one indispensable person, and that leadership is proved by what grows steadier in your absence. At the Mercer table Luca again names a decision cutoff - keep three options alive one more minute or two become stories you almost had - then, refusing to hide inside the word "later," asks Sofia to come with him to Marina Bay after close.

### KNOWLEDGE CHECK

**1. The categories Sofia and Luca use to sort his handoff knowledge are:**

- A) Urgent, later, optional, archive
- B) Sacred, useful, vanity, and escalate if
- C) Wine, food, guests, logistics
- D) Keep, cut, revise, delegate

**2. William Daniels' warning about indispensability is that:**

- A) Good systems need one irreplaceable person
- B) Leadership is proved by what grows steadier in your absence, not by intensity
- C) You should train a single successor
- D) Systems matter more than people

**3. At the Mercer table, Luca names the decision cutoff as:**

- A) "Please decide now"
- B) "I can keep three excellent options alive for about one more minute - after that, two become stories you almost had"
- C) "The kitchen needs your order"
- D) "Let me recommend the duck"

**4. Iris Bell praises Sofia's handling of Luca's absence at the table because she:**

- A) Worked faster than Luca would have
- B) Did not perform his absence - she just served the table as herself
- C) Explained that Luca had been reassigned
- D) Brought a complimentary course

### SERVICE SCENARIO

**You are handing off your regular guests before leaving a restaurant, and you have to decide which details truly matter for the next server versus which only flatter your sense of having been necessary.**

**Walk through how you sort your knowledge into what is sacred, what is useful, what is vanity, and what should trigger escalation - and explain why leaving the room steadier in your absence is the real goal.**

---

---

---

---

---

### SKILLS CHECKLIST

Tick what you own - Circle what you're working on - Leave blank what you haven't started

- ☐ I sort handoff knowledge into what is sacred, useful, vanity, and escalate-if
- ☐ I write notes that serve the next server rather than flatter my own importance
- ☐ I judge my work by what grows steadier in my absence, not by how indispensable I seem
- ☐ I name a decision cutoff so good options do not decay while a table stalls
- ☐ I cover for a departed colleague by serving the table as myself, not by performing their absence

## CHAPTER 11

# Marina Bay / First Kiss

Singapore - Lau Pa Sat hawker centre / Marina Bay

### CHAPTER SUMMARY

After a clean service, Luca and Sofia go to Lau Pa Sat for satay, chicken rice, sambal stingray, and sugar-cane juice under Victorian ironwork - a place too unpretentious to allow performance - because he decided the evening deserved deliberateness rather than an accident he hoped would occur elegantly. Walking to the Marina Bay promenade, he says it is time to stop pretending they do not know what this is, and both admit that some of their restraint had been fear dressed well. He asks "May I kiss you?" before their first kiss, then presses his mouth to the inside of her wrist at the door - clarity delivered on time.

### KNOWLEDGE CHECK

**1. Why does Luca choose Lau Pa Sat, a hawker centre, for the evening?**

- A) It is the cheapest option after service
- B) Nothing about it can pretend to be rarefied - they have to be themselves or nothing
- C) It is closest to staff housing
- D) It has the best skyline view

**2. What most moves Sofia about how Luca approached the evening?**

- A) That he paid for everything
- B) That he treated it as something that mattered and chose deliberateness instead of hoping it would occur elegantly
- C) That he planned a surprise
- D) That he brought her flowers

**3. Before their first kiss, Luca:**

- A) Simply kisses her at the railing
- B) Asks "May I kiss you?" and leaves the briefest pause for refusal
- C) Waits for her to make the first move
- D) Says nothing and takes her hand

**4. At the staff-housing door, instead of kissing her again, Luca:**

- A) Says a brisk good night
- B) Turns her hand and presses his mouth to the inside of her wrist
- C) Hugs her
- D) Walks her inside

### SERVICE SCENARIO

**You are choosing where to take someone for a first real evening after months of restraint, and you want the setting to prevent performance and force honesty rather than manufacture romance.**

**Drawing on Luca's choice of the hawker centre and his decision to treat the night as something that mattered, explain how deliberate care - applied off the floor - creates the conditions for a true moment.**

---

---

---

---

---

### SKILLS CHECKLIST

Tick what you own - Circle what you're working on - Leave blank what you haven't started

- ☐ I choose settings that invite honesty instead of forcing performance
- ☐ I apply the same deliberate care off the floor that I bring to a difficult service
- ☐ I ask before I act rather than assuming consent in an intimate moment
- ☐ I let a real moment stand without improving it with unnecessary language
- ☐ I treat what matters as something to choose deliberately, not hope will happen elegantly

## CHAPTER 12

# Opposite Terminals

Singapore - Changi Airport (Terminal 1 international / Terminal 3 domestic)

### CHAPTER SUMMARY

On departure day, Luca and Sofia move through a final Singapore shift and a shared car to Changi, refusing to let emotion blur sequence - precision matters most when feeling wants blur. At a standing table near the concourse, over deliberately bad coffee, Sofia names a standard rather than a plea: she refuses to go back to pretending this is ordinary, and Luca answers that he can do distance honestly but not vaguely. They part at the split point - she to Terminal 1 for Buenos Aires, he to Terminal 3 for Sydney - with one exact kiss, and she texts from the plane: whatever comes next, don't go vague on me.

### KNOWLEDGE CHECK

**1. Luca's guiding standard for the day of departure is:**

- A) Say everything before the flight
- B) We do not make stupid mistakes because emotion wants to blur sequence
- C) Keep it light so no one cries
- D) Avoid the airport goodbye entirely

**2. At the concourse table, Sofia's final message is best described as:**

- A) A plea for him to follow her
- B) A standard - a refusal to go back to pretending this is ordinary
- C) A promise to visit soon
- D) A request for reassurance

**3. Luca's answer to her standard is:**

- A) "I need more time"
- B) "I can do distance honestly. I cannot do it vaguely"
- C) "Let's not make promises"
- D) "I will call every day"

**4. The "opposite terminals" of the title refer to the fact that:**

- A) They fly the same airline from different gates
- B) Sofia departs from international Terminal 1 for Buenos Aires and Luca from domestic Terminal 3 for Sydney
- C) They miss each other at the airport
- D) They take different cars to Changi

### SERVICE SCENARIO

**You are working a full service on a day when your own life is about to change dramatically, and emotion keeps trying to pull your attention out of sequence and into distraction.**

**Explain how you keep precision under emotional pressure - reading each table for what it actually needs - and why staying in your body and your sequence is itself a form of respect for the work and the guests.**

---

---

---

---

---

### SKILLS CHECKLIST

Tick what you own - Circle what you're working on - Leave blank what you haven't started

- ☐ I keep precision and sequence intact even when emotion wants to blur them
- ☐ I read each table for what it needs - quieter, faster, or simply recognized
- ☐ I recognize a returning guest's preferences as a form of welcome
- ☐ I name a standard honestly instead of hiding behind vagueness
- ☐ I give a clean exit rather than making someone do an emotional job twice

## ANSWER KEY

# Knowledge Check Answers

With explanations.

---

### Ch. 1 - TOKYO / SEPARATE MASTERY

**1. Answer: B) "Too many words"**

Her recitation of origin, polishing ratio, and pairing left the Japanese host's table off balance. The fix was subtraction, not more information.

**2. Answer: B) The interval or space - the pause that gives service its shape**

Ma is interval, space, the pause that gives music shape. Sofia reframes it as silence being a quality of attention rather than the absence of speech.

**3. Answer: C) An instrument - cold narrows and sharpens, warm amplifies umami**

Temperature is a variable that changes the flavor itself, not just the impression: cold narrows and sharpens, room temperature opens, warm amplifies umami and softens acid.

**4. Answer: B) The kitchen is working in restraint and the sake matches that quiet register**

Luca describes the room, not the bottle - the menu is quiet and restrained, so a dry, precise, almost quiet sake is right. William notes most people only describe the bottle.

### Ch. 2 - BANGKOK / HEAT, TEMPO, ORBIT

**1. Answer: B) "Faster for this table"**

The celebrating table wanted its crest held, not rebuilt after each delay. His careful intervals had been serving his own order, not the table's temperature.

**2. Answer: B) Pic Saint-Loup in the Languedoc**

She suggests a dry, structured rose from Pic Saint-Loup in the Languedoc - more structure than expected, chosen to lift the kitchen rather than compete with it.

**3. Answer: C) The warmest move is bringing everyone to the same place without anyone feeling pushed**

She used a sequence, not a compromise - letting hosts set the tone, then shifting register for the reserved couple, so all four arrived at the same warmth without being pushed.

**4. Answer: B) He should allow true praise to land cleanly instead of converting it to future pressure**

His reflex was "I'll do better next time." Khun Nok teaches reception - some accuracy involves letting honest acknowledgment land rather than turning it into pressure.

### Ch. 3 - YAOWARAT / EVIDENCE

**1. Answer: B) Her laugh, carrying a soft Portuguese shape**

He hears the laugh before he finds the face - the same bright laugh from La Boqueria two years earlier. He had kept the sound and lost the face.

**2. Answer: B) Noticing his left pocket prints rectangular and he touched it twice before sitting**

She reads the rectangular print in his pocket and the fact that he touched it twice - the same anticipatory reading skill applied off the floor. He calls it invasive; she calls it awareness.

**3. Answer: B) Boat noodles**

The woman with silver at her temples sets down two bowls of boat noodles, iron-rich and peppered - broth Sofia says has solved problems none of them have earned yet.

**4. Answer: B) The whole job**

She recognizes the decision inside the story - choosing to stay past the answer that technically closed the question. "That's the whole job."

### Ch. 4 - AFTER EVIDENCE / DAILY CONTACT

**1. Answer: B) "You corrected the temperature without touching the thermostat too hard"**

Sofia offered a private dessert acknowledgment angled toward the couple, resetting the table's center without confrontation - a correction made without over-adjusting.

**2. Answer: C) She positions her body at an angle and pitches her voice down so only they hear**

She stands to the right of the couple with her back at a slight angle to the Swiss guests and pitches her voice down - arranging the room's sightlines and acoustics through her own geometry.

**3. Answer: B) Tell him friendliness is not a tasting note unless the wine did him a personal favor**

His reply reframes vague description as a real fault without humiliating: friendliness is not a tasting note. Correct the information, keep the person intact.

**4. Answer: B) Maps traffic density, queue length, and which stalls locals trust - while thinking he is just shopping**

He assesses temperature and rhythm the way he reads a dining room before service - he cannot turn it off, and neither can she. It is simply how they both see.

**1. Answer: A) Monsoon Valley Colombar**

He recommends the Monsoon Valley Colombar as honest enough for the first courses, then suggests moving to cold beer - describing Bangkok rather than showing off the list.

**2. Answer: B) Guests often choose the wrong noun for the correct discomfort**

The dish did contain tamarind; what she smelled was the fermented note in the glaze. The language around the dish had failed her, not the dish - so he hands the real shape back to her.

**3. Answer: B) "You corrected the note without embarrassing the note"**

The discipline underneath: systems are only useful if they protect the real shape of a concern. You fix the information without destroying the person who carried it.

**4. Answer: B) Brazilian Portuguese, a bright laugh, and describing a dish as if she had listened to the plate first**

Brazilian, the room-changing laugh, and the dish described as if heard from the food itself - recognition finally catching up to material that had been waiting for it.

**Ch. 6 - THE FASTER RHYTHM**

**1. Answer: B) Learn the sightlines first, and do not charm when precision will do**

The room teaches by subtraction. Claire values precision over charm and tells Sofia to learn the sightlines before anything else.

**2. Answer: A) 2012 Pauillac at \$2040**

Mei sold the 2012 Pauillac from the reserve list for two thousand and forty dollars, yet her weekly tip came out close to a colleague who ran ninety-dollar Viogniers.

**3. Answer: B) Total covers and total sales**

Claire explains it is weighted by total covers and total sales. A sales-only pool would create perverse incentives - servers angling for wine tables while support staff go underpaid.

**4. Answer: B) The system works for the house, though it does not always work for the person**

The pool flattens variation because the floor works as a floor, not a collection of individual bounties - it works for the house even when it does not always work for the individual.

**Ch. 7 - PRESSURE BECOMES REAL**

**1. Answer: B) Half-seconds - a junior left waiting, a host read twice**

She says the floor can feel invisible weather faster than management admits. Distraction enters through half-seconds, not spectacle.

**2. Answer: B) The guests value privacy and pace, and it would read as theater**

He argues the table values privacy and pace over performance - "Regional is not seated there." Sofia backs him: strong tables want clarity more than false optionality.

**3. Answer: B) "I can keep three excellent paths open for you for another minute - after that, one of them stops being real"**

She lets them enjoy their indecision just long enough, then names a real cutoff - keeping options open was how they exercised control, not genuine confusion.

**4. Answer: B) Did not flatter them by pretending delay was sophistication**

The line lands clean and correct: she refused to treat stalling as refinement, naming the viable path before indecision turned contagious.

**Ch. 8 - FUTURES THAT MAY SPLIT THEM**

**1. Answer: B) A reentry architecture problem - managing returns, not absences**

The daughter is the load-bearing wall, leaving for Hong Kong legal calls. The table does not need her to stay; it needs to be able to hold her returns cleanly.

**2. Answer: B) He waits at the edge of the table, not in her path, and says she has missed nothing important**

He gives gratitude nowhere to go so she can give it back to her family - no demand for explanation, no sympathetic performance, just a landing already in place.

**3. Answer: B) That it sounded like a serious room asking for her specifically, not a competency screen**

Camila took notes without pretending admiration and disliked fake eagerness - a conversation between people who knew what the work cost, not a resume check.

**4. Answer: B) Not wanting less for each other, but helping the other want honestly**

Support had become sacrifice without either withdrawing it. Neither asked the other to get smaller, which was harder and more honest than reassurance.

**Ch. 9 - THE ROOM UNDER STRAIN**

**1. Answer: B) If a guest tells us something important once, they should not have to explain it again**

She prizes ownership: holiday pressure makes people duplicate questions, and a guest should not restate what already cost them something to say because a handoff failed.

**2. Answer: B) It would force the daughter to publicly identify herself as the guest with the allergy in front of her family**

Beyond the safety risk, the harm was social: making her raise her hand and become the guest with the condition. He takes the



**3. Answer: B) One owner, one allergy path, one table memory**

One owner, one path, held all the way through, so the modification never has to be rediscovered and the daughter never has to speak the vulnerable fact twice.

**4. Answer: B) Guests should only explain once**

He translates the table lesson into human scale: rooms fail people by making them restate what cost them something. He does not want them doing that with the next part.

**Ch. 10 - DECISION CUTOFF / FINAL SINGAPORE EVENINGS**

**1. Answer: B) Sacred, useful, vanity, and escalate if**

She forces the knowledge into sacred, useful, vanity, and escalate if - which gives the document a spine. Luca privately notes it is really a scoring rubric.

**2. Answer: B) Leadership is proved by what grows steadier in your absence, not by intensity**

People call building around one person excellence until that person leaves and the place apologizes for itself. Love and leadership are proved by what grows steadier once you are gone.

**3. Answer: B) "I can keep three excellent options alive for about one more minute - after that, two become stories you almost had"**

It works as a diagnosis, not pressure: leaving things open felt like care but was actually watching good options decay into adequate ones.

**4. Answer: B) Did not perform his absence - she just served the table as herself**

"Your colleague did not perform your absence. That was intelligent." She made the table her own without imitating him or performing continuity.

**Ch. 11 - MARINA BAY / FIRST KISS**

**1. Answer: B) Nothing about it can pretend to be rarefied - they have to be themselves or nothing**

Hawker centres demand appetite and proximity and do not permit performance for long. It is the right place for the evening to begin because it cannot be theatrical.

**2. Answer: B) That he treated it as something that mattered and chose deliberateness instead of hoping it would occur elegantly**

He extended the discipline he brings to a difficult service to the care of not wasting this - choosing clarity rather than hoping for it.

**3. Answer: B) Asks "May I kiss you?" and leaves the briefest pause for refusal**

After months of restraint he still chose not to take even this without naming it - one hand at her face, a pause left for refusal, then the kiss.

**4. Answer: B) Turns her hand and presses his mouth to the inside of her wrist**

He lifts her hand, turns it, and kisses the inside of her wrist - brief, precise, "aiming for memorable" - rather than cheapening the evening by kissing her again immediately.

**Ch. 12 - OPPOSITE TERMINALS**

**1. Answer: B) We do not make stupid mistakes because emotion wants to blur sequence**

A shared standard: precision matters most when emotion wants blur. It applies to packing, to the drive, and to clearing security cleanly.

**2. Answer: B) A standard - a refusal to go back to pretending this is ordinary**

Not a declaration but a refusal to re-enter the careful adjacent months and stopped sentences. "I just refuse to go back to pretending this is ordinary."

**3. Answer: B) "I can do distance honestly. I cannot do it vaguely"**

The sentence goes through her with surgical precision - he matches her refusal of vagueness with his own, choosing honest distance over a comfortable blur.

**4. Answer: B) Sofia departs from international Terminal 1 for Buenos Aires and Luca from domestic Terminal 3 for Sydney**

International and domestic - separate sequences, boards, and clocks. Infrastructure collaborates with theme as she heads to Buenos Aires and he to Sydney.

# Keep going.

ServeMaster Academy - Training the next generation  
of hospitality professionals.